



DEEP ROOTS: First non-Brahmin conference in 1917 (above); office bearers of the Justice Party (right)

shifts in the movement's politics committing DMK to electoral politics and withdrew separatist demands. It's argued that this was done to satisfy the growing demand of the local bourgeoisie to strengthen ties across India. Annadurai was a political communicator par excellence. He and his lieutenant M. Karunanidhi used theatre and film to propagate their ideas, questioning the validity of religious traditions and resuscitated the glories of the Sangam Age. A great political storm was sweeping through Tamil Nadu and the Congress succumbed to it, as the indefatigable Congress leader K. Kamaraj was defeated by a DMK student leader in 1967. The DMK got enough seats at its first electoral attempt in the 1950s to become the main opposition. By 1967, it became the majority party and Annadurai was the



chief minister. The Dravidian movement had come of age. The propaganda strategy of the movement soon moved from theatre to films with Karunanidhi playing a big role in the shift.

The actor who portrayed the pro-DMK hero naturally attracted much attention. Sivaji Ganeshan was the first such symbol but he soon dropped out, moving into films with religious and domestic themes. Maruthoor Gopal Ramachandran, popularly known as MGR, then emerged as the icon of DMK. Karunanidhi took over the leadership of the party, but DMK after Annadurai was ridden with internal quarrels. Using the popular support he enjoyed, MGR broke away in 1972 to form Anna Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (ADMK)—which later became AIADMK (All-India ADMK) to avoid any hint of separatism—and became chief minister in 1977. With DMK and AIADMK poised against each other, the Congress government at the Centre took active interest in the politics of the region, often dissolving the assembly to support whichever Dravidian party it stood with.

MGR never emphasised the conflict between Brahmins and non-Brahmins. His constituency was the average downtrodden person. With his death in 1987, his wife V.N. Janaki was brought in as chief minister for a short period. But later, J. Jayalalithaa emerged as the AIADMK leader and came to be seen as heir to the MGR legacy. The former actor became chief minister in 1991 and soon transformed into Amma.

In the last years of the first decade of the 21st century, the Dravidian movement has seen strategic shifts with the rise of every important leader. It is significant then that while the term Dravidian is politically attractive, the state has been unable to resist the growth of the Dalit movement. If the Dalits in Tamil Nadu feel that the Dravidian parties do not include them, the question arises as to what exactly the achievement of the Dravidian movement has been. Its demand for a

Tamil consciousness has brought middle-level backward castes into the power structure but left others behind. Perhaps one of the lasting achievements of the Dravidian movement has been to make Tamils conscious of their legacy, at the same time constituting them as an indivisible part of India.

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